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*(AI-Generated Session Notes)*

# Trust, Verify, Let It Fly: Surfing the Certainty-to-Serendipity Spectrum

**Date & time:** Oct. 14, 3:05-3:40 PM EST
**Track:** Strategic AI




## Jim Sterne

Founder, Coastal Intelligence

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## Session Description

Traditional software makes a promise: ask the same question, get the same answer. Generative AI breaks that promise, making it astonishingly useful.

Marketing operations, analytics, and compliance were built on repeatability and control. But the same model that can reason, summarize, and ideate will also answer differently every time you ask. So the real question is how much uncertainty can this task tolerate.

In this session, Jim Sterne introduces a practical way to match each AI use case to the right level of control. Some tasks run deterministically, some require a human in the loop, and some are exploratory. You need to classify any use case by its tolerance for variation and then decide when AI should automate, assist, or inspire, this session gives your team a shared language for AI risk that speeds adoption instead of stalling it.

## Key Quote

> *"Certainty is avoiding failure. Probability is managing risk. Uncertainty is creating value. Go from enhanced automation to advanced imagination, and just ask better questions."* **- Jim Sterne**

## Session Summary

Jim Sterne, founder of Coastal Intelligence and author of 13 books on online marketing, opened his session by giving the audience three words to work with: deterministic, probabilistic, and generative. Deterministic systems are the computers we grew up with, where two plus two is always four and you put data in and get the same data out. Probabilistic systems estimate and forecast, and generative systems produce something new. He compared the three to states of matter: you can stand on a block of ice, water reliably flows to the lowest level, and the generative state is all over the place.

Sterne mapped each mode to marketing work. Payroll, loyalty points, and URL tracking codes should be deterministic because nobody wants surprises there. Sales forecasts, customer lifetime value, and lead scoring are probabilistic. He briefly explained supervised, unsupervised, and reinforcement learning, noted that GPT stands for generative pre-trained transformer, and

urged attendees to lean into the generative side for brainstorming and exploration, even calling on them to lean into the hallucination.

Turning to agentic AI, he framed the key question as how much agency to give the machine. Some tasks stay fully human, such as telling someone they are being let go. Others call for being in the loop (forecasting, campaign strategy), on the loop (lead scoring, reviewing hundreds of creative treatments), watching the loop (monthly segmentation), or out of the loop entirely (competitor reports, programmatic advertising). Humans keep three jobs: defining the problem, choosing the information AI should consider, and applying the smell test, because gut feel, office dynamics, and moral boundaries are not in the training data. He also highlighted a useful twist: generative AI is very good at writing deterministic code, because software is objectively verifiable and can be run, tested, and fixed until it works.

The heart of the talk was a push from enhanced automation to advanced imagination. Sterne shared custom prompts he built for conference attendees, including a culturally aware donor postcard campaign, an interviewer agent that captures institutional knowledge from direct reports, a fictional rival built from lost-deal interviews to train salespeople, an internal relationship navigator for a new employee, a blind proposal review process, and a delegation plan that would make a CMO's 30-day absence uneventful. He also suggested building persona-based advisory boards and asking detractors for their views on a campaign.

In the Q&A, Sterne explained how to use a meta prompt to have AI write the prompt that creates an agent, and observed that people often accept critique from a machine more easily than from a boss. Asked how to build creativity, he called AI a gymnasium for creativity, described his Claude system prompt that requests three orthogonal thoughts at the end of every response, and recommended asking AI to critique you, argue against you, and keep pushing for ideas further outside the box.

## Key Takeaways

- **Match the mode to the task.** Use deterministic systems where surprises are unacceptable, probabilistic tools for forecasting and scoring, and generative AI for exploration and brainstorming.
- **Decide how much agency to give.** For each use case, choose whether humans do it, stay in the loop, watch on the loop, or let AI run out of the loop.
- **Own the three human jobs.** Defining the problem, choosing the information, and applying the smell test stay with people because context and gut feel are not in the training data.
- **Use generative AI to build certainty.** Because code is objectively verifiable, generative AI can write, test, and fix deterministic software you can count on.
- **Ask bigger, stranger questions.** Prompts that simulate stakeholders, invent a fictional rival, or plan for your absence move AI from enhanced automation to advanced imagination.
- **Exercise your creativity muscle.** Ask AI for orthogonal thoughts, critique, and counterarguments, and keep pushing it further outside the box.